FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Uttar Pradesh has lived through decades of having its aspirations smothered by a deeply compromised system, an edifice built on a nexus of crime, politics and corrupt officialdom. While the leaders at the top waged their battles around slogans of caste and religion, powerful ganglords who operated on both sides of the law brought in much of the capital. The striking thing about UP's underworld was that it lived so brazenly overground: its leading lights were and are regular faces in the state's politics and routinely reached the assembly and Parliament. Crime lords consorting with power started with the Congress, and the BJP has had decades of entrenchment in that system too. The state cabinet career of UP's original don, Hari Shankar Tiwari, is proof enough of the ideology-free nature of organised crime and its interface with politics—he served under Kalyan Singh, Mulayam Singh Yadav, Rajnath Singh and Mayawati.

The murder of don Atiq Ahmed by three pistol-toting youngsters on live television on April 15, despite a posse of policemen around him, brought to an end one of the biggest chapters in the story of UP's mafia. Atiq's career ran on parallel tracks. Even as he gained ascendancy in the underworld, so did his political career. He won the Allahabad West assembly seat as an Independent in 1989, 1991 and 1993, before retaining it in 1996 as a Samajwadi Party candidate. He switched to the Apna Dal soon after and won again in 2002. He then returned to the SP and won the Phulpur Lok Sabha seat in 2004. The next year, Atiq was accused of killing BSP MLA Raju Pal, who had defeated his younger brother in the seat vacated by him. He then rejoined the Apna Dal and even served as its president, unsuccessfully contesting the Lok Sabha election in 2009 from Pratapgarh. By then, he had emerged as UP's top ganglord. His notoriety was writ in a history-sheet glittering with dozens of heinous crimes—over 100 cases at final count—but that was always an enabling factor in his political career, not a deterrent. Even as an undertrial, he ran his nefarious network from prison, as with the infamous case of a realtor's extortion. His life journey clearly exemplifies the unholy nexus that exists between the crime mafia and politics.



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When Yogi Adityanath emerged as the surprise choice for chief minister in 2017 following the BJP's massive win in the assembly election, one of his major tasks was to bring about the rule of law in the disorder that prevailed. He made it clear that he had "zero tolerance" towards crime. Police were given a free hand and they used controversial means to bring justice, including killing many criminals in encounters and using bulldozers to mow down their illegal constructions. The purpose was for the criminals to feel the pain immediately rather than wait for results of our plodding judicial system. While Yogi faced criticism for many of these actions that skirted the edge of law, the tough measures won him plaudits for the perceived improvement in the law-and-order situation. This was one of the main reasons for his and the BJP's return to power in the 2022 assembly election.

In his second term, Yogi focused more on economic revival and attracting investments, assuring peace as a precondition. Cracking down on mafia lords who had become a law unto themselves was integral to his plans for UP's perestroika. After studying the murky criminal landscape, 66 mafia lords were identified and exhaustive dossiers prepared on them, detailing each of their crimes and studying their weak links. The state's feeble prosecutorial wing was given a shot of adrenaline: compromised lackeys were shunted out, new prosecutors willing to nail a case brought in, tough judges given the right cases, and witnesses protection. Criminals who evaded the law were also ruthlessly hunted down and, if they resisted, shot down. Yogi is mindful of the criticism that the crackdown was being targeted at Muslims. His officers point out that of the 66 dons on the state's most wanted list, only 13 are Muslim. And of the 183 police encounters, Muslims account for 32 per cent.

The crackdown began paying dividends as the mafia dons experienced the strong arm of the law. Atiq Ahmed was convicted by a court for the first time ever, and given life imprisonment for intimidating Umesh Pal—a key witness in the Raju Pal case. It was when Umesh Pal was gunned down in broad daylight in February this year, allegedly by a squad headed by Atiq's third son Asad, that Yogi went ballistic. In the assembly, after SP leader Akhilesh Yadav taunted him about law and order, Yogi vowed he would reduce the mafia to dust (*"mitti mein mila denge"*). When Asad failed to surrender, a police posse tracked him down and when he allegedly opened fire at them, they gunned him down along with his accomplice on April 13. Two days later, Atiq and his younger brother Ashraf fell to their assailants' bullets.

That's where the script went awry. While the overall crackdown of the mafia was popular, the Atiq killing is a deviation Yogi could have done without. He already had Atiq pinned to the wall legally and the way the shooting occurred under police watch has damaged the UP police force's credibility. What made matters worse was that the three killers chanted 'Jai Shri Ram' while surrendering. Opposition leaders have often pointed to the ethical, moral and legal-constitutional questions around Yogi's crackdown, and its implicit religion- and caste-based partisanship. The circumstances surrounding the Atiq incident bring them into focus in a way that the chief minister has no choice but to respond. In our cover story this week, our Lucknow Special Correspondent Prashant Srivastava maps out Yogi's head-on combat with the mafia, its successes and pitfalls.

The manner of Atiq's killing is no doubt reprehensible and raises a disturbing set of questions. The ganglord was known to have had deep contacts on all sides of officialdom, including among the police, administrators, and even senior leaders across the political spectrum. Unless those who commissioned the hit job are brought to book by the justice system, it would mean the rest of the iceberg is still intact. Speaking at a public function three days after the killing, Yogi said how the mafia and professional criminals could no longer threaten citizens and get away with it and that the rule of law would prevail. The onus lies on him and the UP administration to ensure it does while he continues his campaign against the crime lords of his state.

(Aroon Purie)